

## WILLIAM PETER HAMILTON

1867–1929

William Peter Hamilton, the future executive editor of both the *Wall Street Journal* and *Barron's*, was born in Scotland. As a young man he worked as a clerk on the London Stock Exchange and then as a correspondent for the *Pall Mall Gazette*. But like fellow Scotsman B. C. Forbes, Hamilton sought adventure in South Africa, where he served in the British army, acted as a war correspondent, and dabbled in the Johannesburg stock market. In 1899, he came to the United States and joined the *Wall Street Journal* staff. In 1908, Hamilton became editor of the *Wall Street Journal's* editorial page and acting executive editor, and remained so until he died. Hamilton also served as executive editor for *Barron's* from the day it was launched in 1921.

Clarence W. Barron (who was quite a character, standing 5 feet 5 inches and weighing over 300 pounds) bought a controlling interest in Dow Jones & Company in 1902. "He was the most astonishing worker I ever saw," Hamilton wrote. "He would begin a conversation with me while carrying on business with two secretaries and attending to two telephones. Barron's flamboyant character influenced Hamilton, and editorials that were once characterized as "urbane and placid" became more edgy. Hamilton hit his stride as writer in 1922 when he penned *The Stock Market Barometer*, a very well received book that presented his interpretation of the Dow theory.

Before Charles Dow died in 1902, Hamilton had had a number of conversations with him concerning stock market behavior, and in 1929 that influence became evident. On October 15, he warned against the "speculative frenzy" on Wall Street. Then on October 25, just days before Black Tuesday on the 29th, Hamilton declared the bull market over in an editorial entitled "A Turn in the Tide." He wrote, "On the late Charles H. Dow's well-known method of reading the stock market movement from the Dow-Jones averages, the twenty railroad stocks on Wednesday, October 23, confirmed a bearish indication given by the industrials two days before. In *The Dow Theory*, Hamilton takes a critical look at Charles Dow's ideas and how they can be used to take the gambling out of investing.